

live far away from the office to avoid paying high rent, and then your commute costs you time and money. Now that I was working in a TV production office (and not as a grungy nighttime crime reporter), I needed new clothes that didn't have spaghetti stains on them. I needed button-downs, pencil skirts, and nice pants. I'd try and get them cheap from less expensive places, but the shirts were so poorly made they always ripped under the armpits if I moved the wrong way or unraveled at the seams as I made coffee runs. I never looked as good as the other interns, and I worried my bosses saw me as sloppy because of it.

Stealing clothing became a constant fantasy. I'd look in the windows of stores and wonder if I could just bargain with the salesperson for some kind of discount. I imagined having invisibility powers, the ability to walk in and walk out with ten usable work skirts. In a particularly rough moment, I actually did try to shoplift a skirt from one popular retail chain. There was a branch of the store in downtown Manhattan that I'd sometimes go into to torture myself. I'd walk around looking at all the clothing and jewelry I couldn't afford, telling myself it wasn't emotional cutting; I was just seeing what was trendy to try and re-create at cheaper stores later.

This particular day, I was so overwhelmed that I became angry with the store itself. How dare it get to decide what I could and could not have? Its prices were a personal attack on me and people like me. If I stole something, I'd be doing everyone a favor.

I walked out with the skirt. And I was immediately caught.

The security guard called me back, pulled the skirt out of my purse, and asked where the receipt was. I didn't have a receipt, and I acted surprised the skirt had somehow fallen into my small purse. He started to walk me back into the store, but I left the skirt in his hands and took off running. I ran for blocks, tears streaming down my face.

This was a new low. This was desperation. I had to admit to myself that financially, things were not just bad; they were crushing me. My health was declining, and I was doing shit that was impulsive. What good would it do to put *The Daily Show* on my résumé if I'd also have to add a shoplifting conviction? Winona Ryder was an icon, but I wasn't looking to copy her downward spiral. (Although, wow, *Stranger Things*! What a comeback!)